



Questions to Ask When You've Been Diagnosed With Cancer

If you have been told you have cancer, you might have a lot of questions. Your doctor or cancer care team is the best place to start. Don't be afraid to ask.

Some doctors wait for you to ask questions, but you may not know where to start. It might help to write down questions as you think of them and take a list with you to your appointments. Here are some ideas to get you started.

When you're told you have cancer

- ☐ Why do you think I have cancer?
- ☐ What kind of cancer do you think I have?
- ☐ Where in my body do you think it started? Has it spread to other parts?
- ☐ Do you know the stage of the cancer? What does that stage mean for me?
- ☐ Do I need to have other tests? When and where will they be done?
- ☐ How and when will I get the test results? Who will explain them to me?
- ☐ Can biomarker or molecular testing be done for my type of cancer?
- ☐ Should I think about genetic counseling and testing for myself or my family?
- ☐ Do I need to see other types of doctors for my cancer treatment?
- ☐ What are my chances of surviving this cancer?
- ☐ Where can I find more information about this cancer?
- ☐ How and when should I tell my family and friends about my diagnosis?

Deciding on a treatment plan

- ☐ What are my treatment options? Where can I learn more about these options?
- ☐ What treatment do you suggest? Why?
- ☐ What's the goal of this treatment? Do you think it could cure the cancer?
- ☐ What are the risks of this treatment?
- ☐ Are there serious side effects?
- ☐ What are the long-term impacts?
- ☐ Will I be able to have children after treatment? Are there things that can be done to protect my fertility?
- ☐ How soon do I need to start treatment?
- ☐ What will happen if I decide not to get treatment right now?
- ☐ How much experience do you have treating this type of cancer?
- ☐ Should I get a second opinion? How would I do that?
- ☐ Is there a clinical trial that might be right for me?

Insurance and money concerns

- ☐ Who can help me figure out what my insurance covers and what I will have to pay myself?
- ☐ What can I do if I don't have health insurance?
- ☐ What can I do if I can't afford the treatments I need?

- ☐ What financial support can I get to help pay what insurance doesn't cover or with other daily needs?
- ☐ Is there a financial counselor or patient navigator I can talk with?

Getting ready for treatment

- ☐ What will my treatment be like? How long will my treatment last?
- ☐ Where will I go for treatment? Who will do my treatments?
- ☐ What side effects could I have from these treatments?
- ☐ Will I need to take any special precautions while I'm getting treated?
- ☐ What can I do to get ready for treatment?
- ☐ Will I be able to go to work or school, spend time with my family, and be able to do my daily activities during treatment?
- ☐ Can I drive myself to treatment, or should I get a ride? What if I can't find a ride to treatment?
- ☐ Will I need help at home? If so, who can help me figure out how to get the help I'll need?
- ☐ Is there anything I can do to help the treatment work better?
- ☐ Can you suggest a mental health professional I can see if I start to feel anxious, depressed, or distressed?

During treatment

- ☐ What's the best time to call with questions or problems? How quickly can I expect a call back?
- ☐ What if I have a serious problem when your office is closed?
- ☐ Will I need blood tests, imaging scans, or other tests? If so, how often?
- ☐ How will we know if the treatment is working?
- ☐ What would we do if the treatment doesn't work?

- ☐ Do I need to change what I eat during treatment?
- ☐ Will I be able to exercise? What kind of exercise can I do, and how often?
- ☐ What about vitamins or diets that friends tell me about? How will I know if they are safe?

If you are having symptoms or side effects from your cancer or treatment

- ☐ How long are my side effects likely to last?
- ☐ Who can help me control my symptoms and side effects?
- ☐ What can I do on my own to control them?
- ☐ Should I see a palliative care team or doctor to help me cope and manage my symptoms?
- ☐ What symptoms or side effects should I let my you know about?
- ☐ Which ones should I contact you about right away?
- ☐ When do I call my cancer care team? When do I call my primary care provider?
- ☐ When should I go to the emergency room or call 911?

If you choose not to get treated

- ☐ What type of follow-up will I need?
- ☐ Will I continue to see my cancer care team or just my primary care provider?
- ☐ What screening tests should I get for other types of cancer? When should I get them?
- ☐ Who can help me manage my symptoms and cope with my cancer?
- ☐ Would it help if I see a palliative care team?
- ☐ Who should I call about any symptoms?
- ☐ How much longer do you think I will live? Would hospice be a good option for me?



For more information and answers, visit the American Cancer Society website at cancer.org or call us at **1-800-227-2345**. We're here when you need us.



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